

THE QUIET MAN IN THE RED STORM

From self-doubt to IPL glory, Royal Challengers Bengaluru skipper **Rajat Patidar** discusses captaincy, batting evolution and the mindset shaping his career.

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Two things immediately strike you when you watch Rajat Patidar marshalling his troops on the cricket field. First, of course, is the flowing mane and its cascading curls, tinted with an amber hue. Patidar promptly explains that he began nurturing it long before the 'Dhurandhar' effect.

For the relief (or dismay) of all the young adults embroiled in a perennial struggle at home about growing out their hair, being the captain of the Royal Challengers Bengaluru does not absolve you of the tedious process. "Even now, when I go home, my mom, dad and grandpa ask when I'm going to cut my hair. No matter how old you are, you're always a kid to your parents," a smiling Patidar says.

The second is his almost-perfect poker face and zen-like attitude on the pitch. Are the bowlers being carted around the ground, or has the top order collapsed early? The skipper remains expressionless, or at least his facial expressions and body language suggest so. When the franchise approached Patidar to

take over from the departing Faf du Plessis, this was one trait the batter wanted to preserve. "I am calm. I am not that expressive. You can't read anything out of my face. As an individual, I can't let go of my strengths. You perform best when you align with them," he explains.

Show of faith

Patidar does not mind admitting that he was riddled with self-doubt when RCB first hinted at handing him the captaincy. After all, he had played just one full IPL season.

But that majestic hundred in the 2022 Eliminator, followed by a breakout 2024 season in which he scored almost 400 runs at a strike rate of 177.13, had shown the franchise enough.

An Rs. 11-crore retention and the captaincy followed in 2025. No prizes for guessing what happened at the end of that campaign.

"Doubts were recurring until I